reference, invoking Lok Sabha Rule 349, which prohibits MPs from quoting unpublished or unauthenticated documents. Two days later, Gandhi returned to Parliament, brandishing a printed copy, daring the PM to confront him.

Responding to Rahul Gandhi on February 6, BJP MP Nishikant Dubey sought to read out passages from other books critical of the Gandhi family. He was stopped by TDP MP Krishna Prasad Tenneti, who was presiding as Speaker, citing Om Birla's ruling. As the Opposition forced an adjournment, the BJP argued that the restriction did not apply to published material.

The Opposition, led by the Congress, on February 10 submitted a no-confidence notice against Birla signed by 118 MPs, accusing him of "blatantly partisan" conduct. The notice raises three objections—suspension of eight Opposition MPs on February 3, BJP MP Nishikant Dubey's personalised attacks on former PMs Jawaharlal Nehru and Indira Gandhi, and Birla's statement that he had asked PM Modi, who was expected to reply to the President's address on February 6, to avoid the House after intelligence inputs warned of a possible physical "attack" by Opposition MPs. The motion is likely to be taken up on March 9, the first day of the second part of the budget session.

UNFOLDING PLOT

- **Pre-order notices by Penguin Random House India in Nov. 2023 say Gen. Naravane's book *Four Stars of Destiny* was initially slated for publication in Jan. 2024**
- **After reports by the news agency PTI in Dec. 2023 based on circulating extracts, the defence ministry asks Penguin to submit the book for clearance**
- **In Jan. 2024, the army headquarters reviewed the book and put the publication on hold**
- **In Jan. 2026, *Caravan* uses excerpts from Gen. Naravane's memoirs in an article; pirated copies are freely available online**
- **On Feb. 2, Rahul Gandhi attempts to read those excerpts in Parliament to allege the PM and government abdicated responsibility during the India-China face-off in Ladakh in August 2020. All hell breaks loose**

STATUS OF THE BOOK

Gen. Naravane's memoir was scheduled for publication in April 2024. However, after a news agency published extracts in December 2023, the ministry of defence placed the manuscript under review. Yet excerpts have appeared in media reports and the book is reportedly leaked in digital form.

On February 9, Delhi Police registered an FIR to investigate the leak of a "type-set book apparently prepared by Penguin Random House India", found on websites and online marketplaces. The probe targets "unknown persons" for copyright infringement and possible violations of the Official Secrets Act. Pouncing on this, the BJP has repeatedly questioned how Gandhi obtained the book, hinting at illegal possession.

On February 10, both Naravane and Penguin Random House India issued carefully calibrated statements. Penguin said "no copies of the book...have been published, distributed, sold or otherwise made available to the public". Naravane shared this on social media, writing, "This is the status of the book." Naravane did not comment on the political controversy. Penguin did not explain how the PDF had leaked.

The controversy has revived memories of India's confrontation with China in eastern Ladakh in 2020. After clashes between Indian and Chinese troops along the Pangong Tso (or Pangong lake) in April and May, tensions culminated in the Galwan valley clash of June 15, in which 20 Indian and an unspecified number of Chinese soldiers were killed. By mid-2020, Chinese forces had mobilised beyond agreed limits and were inflexible at friction points like PP-14, PP-15 and Pangong Tso. The decisive moment came on the night of August 29–30, when India launched Operation Snow Leopard to pre-empt Chinese moves on the south bank of the lake. Troops swiftly occupied key heights along the Kailash Range, gaining tactical dominance and forcing a shift in Beijing's negotiating posture, leading to disengagement in early 2021. Government sources say that the operation had explicit political approval. "For an offensive action on the LAC, full clearance was necessary. Once it was given, the army had operational autonomy," says a officer involved in the exercise.

Rahul Gandhi's allegations of government inaction, based on the unpublished book, attempt to puncture the BJP's narrative of decisiveness on national security. The BJP argues that Modi's instruction was a vote of confidence for the military leadership. However, critics say that in a face-off with a nuclear-armed adversary, commanders require political clarity on escalation thresholds.

NO POLITICAL DIVIDEND?

Meanwhile, some Congress leaders argue that the China issue has limited traction in pollbound Assam, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Kerala. One Congress strategist puts it bluntly: "Voters care about prices, jobs and local grievances. Instead, we are spending the budget session on a book most people haven't heard of.... It is politically tone-deaf." Gandhi's supporters say he is targeting Modi's greatest asset: his strongman image.

What does Gen. Naravane's memoir say about the 2020 Ladakh crisis? Until the book is published with official clearance, the public must rely on partial accounts. But, in persistently trying to block discussion on it, the government has deepened doubts about its own version of the truth. ■